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The new meaning of office: how hybrid work changes formal organizational structure from a place perspective

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Abstract

Hybrid work has become a central topic in debates about the future of work (FoW). Its rise introduces a dual spatial transformation: employees' physical workspace extends beyond the office to locations like the home, while work itself shifts from analog to virtual spaces. These spatial changes have the potential to reshape formal organizational structures in ways that are neither planned nor anticipated by organizations. Drawing on a place lens, this study explores how hybrid work influences formal structure, i.e., the prescribed grouping of positions and reporting relationships. We analyzed 49 interviews with employees from two international organizations at two points in time. Our findings reveal an emergent trend toward *functional grouping and centralization* of previously decentralized HR positions, which may be followed by *spatial relocation*. We argue that these structural shifts are driven by place re-making activities in both virtual and physical spaces, which redefine employees' sense of the workplace as being virtual. In this virtual workplace, the spatial manifestation of formal structures dissolves, creating a window of opportunity for organizational decision makers to revise established structural arrangements. At the same time, the virtual workplace falls short in fulfilling employees' need for social connectedness, prompting a reconstitution of the office as a place of social contact. Spatial relocation then serves a dual function: encouraging social interactions within the newly formed teams and re-manifesting changed formal structures in the physical space.

Keywords Hybrid work · Place-making · Workplace · Future of work · Organizational structure · Communication technologies

JEL Classification M0 · M5

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1 Introduction

Work and employment are undergoing considerable transformations, including when and where work is performed (Aroles et al. 2019). Scholarly debates about the future of work (FoW) investigate such change, considering how emerging phenomena will affect the nature of work and employment in the near and distant future (Dries et al. 2025) across a wide array of technological, social, economic, and political dimensions (Santana and Cobo 2020). One of the most significant developments in this realm concerns the spatiality of work, with knowledge work being increasingly performed virtually (Malhotra 2021) and with higher numbers of employees working full- or part-remotely than ever before (López-Igual and Rodríguez-Modroño, 2020).

Within the broader FoW debate, the present study focuses on hybrid work, a development that was accelerated during the COVID-19 pandemic and is expected to become increasingly common (Allen et al. 2024; Oppong Peprah 2024). In organizational practice, hybrid work is typically understood as a flexible arrangement in which employees divide their working hours between the company premises and other locations, typically the home (Trevor and Holweg 2022). Enabled by advanced information and communication technologies (AICTs) that allow employees to communicate and conduct work virtually (Greer and Payne 2014), hybrid work decouples work from fixed spatial arrangements, promoting a multiplicity of workspaces (Aroles et al. 2019). Recent scholarly work adds more nuance to our understanding of hybrid work. For example, Vartiainen and Vanharanta (2024) see it as a flexible combination of physical, virtual, social, and temporal work elements, whose configuration shapes organizational consequences such as employee wellbeing and performance. Following Lauring and Jonasson (2025), in this paper we understand hybrid work as ongoing alternations between traditional and non-traditional work modes across the dimensions of modality (analog vs. virtual space), location (office-bound vs. distributed), and temporality (constrained vs. unconstrained), and we focus on the two spatial dimensions (modality and location).

Workspaces physically and symbolically materialize organizational structures, including hierarchies, communication patterns, and team boundaries (Taylor and Spicer 2007). At the same time, research on digitalization suggests that a shift from analog to virtual workspaces has the potential to facilitate adaptive activities within an organization and therefore serves as an opportunity for organizational transformation (Barley 1986; Tyre and Orlikowski 1994). Changes in workspaces may therefore also reconfigure the structures embedded within them. Against this backdrop, we assume that the spatial changes associated with hybrid work shape organizations in ways that are consequential but not always predictable, and we ask: *How, and through which mechanisms, does the introduction of hybrid work affect formal organizational structure?*

The formal structure of an organization is the division of labor into formal positions, teams or departments, encompassing reporting relationships, decision-making authority, and the grouping of organizational units (Mintzberg 1979, 1980). It determines formal relationships and the allocation of authority across the organization (Mintzberg 1979, 1980; Pham et al. 2022) and is distinct from informal organiza-

tional structures such as communication norms or social practices in that it is explicitly prescribed (e.g., in the form of a company organigram).

Despite formal structure's importance for coordination and communication within and between groups (Pham et al. 2022), it remains largely unclear how the spatial changes associated with hybrid work influence it. There is scientific evidence that organizations can support strategic organizational change through targeted spatial adaptations (e.g., office design). Much of the existing research, however, has examined such changes in contexts where spatial redesign is introduced as a deliberate managerial intervention (Skogland 2017; Kingma 2019). More commonly, however, organizations implement hybrid work as a spatial change *not* primarily as a restructuring tool. This is the setting of this paper, in which we examine how spatial changes become consequential for *formal* organizational structure.

Research on new ways of working (NWW)—an organizational design concept that integrates the virtualization of work with spatial flexibilization and cultural change—provides an important starting point for this inquiry. As a related literature stream, it centers on the technology-enabled flexibilization of where and how work is performed, similar to research on hybrid work. Literature in this field has shown that targeted spatial interventions can have unexpected or paradoxical effects on – mainly informal – structures like tighter instead of looser managerial control (Aroles et al. 2021). The consequences for the *formal* structure remain less well understood. A wide range of structural outcomes appears possible as the information- and communication-properties of AICTs can simultaneously foster formal structural centralization and decentralization (Bloom et al. 2014, p. 2860). How such effects unfold remains underexplored.

In summary, empirical evidence on organizational effects of flexible work arrangements, including but not limited to hybrid work, remains inconclusive (e.g., Aroles et al. 2019; Bloom et al. 2014; Renard et al. 2021). Malhotra (2021) calls for multidisciplinary research that moves beyond individual work arrangements to examine how organizations can be designed or structured for the future of work. We answer this call by tracing the spatial mechanisms through which hybrid work reshapes formal organizational structure. To do so, we conducted a longitudinal qualitative study of 26 employees across two organizations that introduced hybrid work following the COVID-19 lockdowns.

Our inquiry focused on the emergent structural changes that resulted from hybrid work rather than deliberate top-down restructuring initiatives. For our analysis, we draw on a place lens, an established framework in human geography and, more recently, organizational studies (Cartel et al. 2022; Taylor and Spicer 2007). Place theory holds that spaces become imbued with socially constructed meaning through ongoing enactment, thus becoming meaningful places, and that individuals' sense of place encodes behavioral expectations and manifests organizational structures (Harrison and Dourish 1996; Taylor and Spicer 2007). Because hybrid work fundamentally disrupts established spatial meanings, it triggers place re-making processes that, we argue, have the potential to alter not only informal but also formal organizational structures.

The study makes three major contributions. First, it links research on hybrid work with a place lens, shifting attention from space as a dimension of hybrid work to

the processes through which employees experience and enact their workspaces. This processual view illuminates not only changing perceptions of place, but also how they relate to organizational consequences beyond the individual employee level. It thereby speaks to a central concern of the FoW debate: how the changing spatiality of work reshapes organizations.

Second, our findings extend organizational research by demonstrating the mechanisms through which hybrid work can trigger not only informal but also formal structural change. Place theory has shown how physical workspaces give spatial manifestation to structures (Taylor and Spicer 2007), but it has not been systematically connected to formal structural change. Doing so proves theoretically productive as we show that the withdrawal of the spatial manifestation creates a window of opportunity in which established structural arrangements become open to revision.

Third, our findings document a new meaning of the office as a place for social connectedness. While the virtual workplace enabled collaboration and individual work successfully, it did not fulfill employees' need for social contact. The office thus retains an important function that the virtual workplace cannot replace, even when employees work predominantly from home.

2 Theoretical background

The application of place theory to organizational contexts is a rather new but growing area of inquiry (Cartel et al. 2022), as researchers increasingly acknowledge that place is not merely a backdrop to organizational life, but that it plays an important role for both organizational functioning and the experience of organizational members (Lawrence and Dover 2015).

In place theory, *space* and *place* are related but distinct concepts. *Space* refers to a physical or virtual locus in which interactions occur (Cartel et al. 2022). In this sense, a workspace is any setting in which organizational members conduct work, store documents or work devices, communicate, or collaborate (Leone 2023). While traditional definitions of space emphasize a fixed physical location and material form (Gieryn 2000), contemporary work takes a broader view that encompasses virtual environments (Leone 2023). Virtual spaces draw on many features of physical spaces. For example, they use audio, video, and spatial models to digitally replicate physical settings and thereby create a virtual locus of activity (Harrison and Dourish 1996).

Place, by contrast, is space that has been imbued with meaning (Lawrence and Dover 2015). Following Cartel et al. (2022), we define place as a "unique location (either geographical or digital), endowed with a material form (either crafted by nature or humans) and a socially constructed set of meanings" (p. 350). Individuals ascribe meaning to locations – by inhabiting, enacting, experiencing and forming memories within them – thereby transforming the space into a place (Cilliers and Timmermans 2014). The theoretical mechanism by which space becomes place is known as *place-making* (Cartel et al. 2022). It can occur through the deliberate design of a physical or virtual space (Harrison and Dourish 1996), but also through the more organic accumulation of shared experiences within it (Cresswell 2014). Over time, place-making gives rise to a *sense of place*, which is individuals' "subjec-

tive and emotional attachment" to a place (Cartel et al. 2022, p. 354). This sense of place is not static. External changes that disrupt the established sense of place can facilitate place re-making, a process by which the sense of place is renegotiated and reconstructed.

The relationship between individuals and places runs in both directions. Just as individuals shape places, places shape individuals ' behavior. This means that place-making is not only a process of giving meaning to space, but also a process through which organizational action becomes patterned. Once a space is experienced as a particular kind of place, it carries expectations about what can and should happen there (Svobodova et al. 2023). A meeting room, a manager's office, a shared team area, a corridor, or a digital collaboration channel do not only provide a setting for action. They suggest appropriate forms of conduct, interaction, visibility, accessibility, and coordination. In this sense, place-making links the material and symbolic qualities of space with situated behavior: organizational members enact places through their everyday activities, while these places, once established, orient future activities.

This relationship becomes particularly relevant when considering organizational structure. Broadly, organizational structure refers to how work is divided and coordinated (Mintzberg 1980). A distinction can be made between formal and informal structure. Formal structure comprises officially defined arrangements, such as positions, units, departments, reporting lines, authority relations, specialization, formalization, centralization, and coordination mechanisms. It is usually expressed in organizational charts, role descriptions, rules, and procedures (Hunter 2015; Mintzberg 1980). Informal structure, in contrast, refers to emergent patterns of interaction that develop through everyday behavior, including advice seeking, information sharing, friendship ties, collaboration routines, and informal communication networks (Hunter 2015). Formal and informal structures are analytically distinct, but they are closely intertwined in organizational practice. Formal roles shape who is expected to interact with whom, while repeated informal interactions may support, bypass, or gradually reshape formal coordination patterns.

The connection between place-making and these organizational structures is based on a structurationist view of organizational reality (Whittington 1992) derived from Giddens' (1984) theory of structuration. Central to this perspective is the duality of structure: organizational structures shape and enable action while being reproduced or altered through actors' ongoing practices. Organizational members draw on rules, resources, routines, and expectations embedded in structures when they act, but these actions also sustain or modify the structures on which they draw (Giddens 1984). Formal structure becomes practically real when employees report to managers, coordinate with assigned colleagues, follow procedures, or act according to role expectations. Informal structure emerges when employees repeatedly turn to certain colleagues for information, support, or advice. Structure is therefore not only an abstract organizational arrangement; it is enacted in situated behavior.

Space and place are central to this enactment because structures materialize through spatial arrangements. Hierarchy, for example, can be expressed through office size, spatial distance from management, access rights, floors, corridors, or the visibility of particular actors. Departmental structures may be reinforced when employees belonging to the same unit sit together, use the same meeting rooms, or share

everyday routes through the office. Informal structures are also spatially supported, because proximity, shared break areas, and repeated co-presence make spontaneous interaction and relationship formation more likely. Organizational spaces therefore do not merely reflect structure; they help stabilize it by making formal and informal relations visible, habitual, and meaningful (Gieryn 2000; Taylor and Spicer 2007).

Place-making can therefore provide a link between spatial conditions and organizational structure. Existing structures shape how organizational members use and experience spaces, while changing spatial practices and meanings may, in turn, weaken, reproduce, or contribute to the transformation of established structures. This is especially relevant when workspaces change, because changes in where and how people act may also change how they experience hierarchy, team membership, coordination, and informal contact. Spatial change therefore does not automatically imply structural change. However, it can become structurally relevant when it changes the everyday place-making practices through which organizational members enact and experience formal and informal structures. In this way, the structurationist view complements our place perspective, which similarly conceives places as neither purely material settings nor purely subjective constructions, but as material spaces that acquire socially constructed meanings through their enactment (Cartel et al. 2022).

3 Method

3.1 Research design and case selection

This study applies a qualitative research design, collecting data at three points in time across two organizations. We conducted 49 semi-structured interviews with 26 employees from two international corporations, and two additional expert interviews with senior HR representatives of the same corporations as a member check (Creswell and Miller 2000). This longitudinal design is well suited to the research question because place re-making is an inherently processual phenomenon (drawing on Cartel et al. 2022). By following developments over time, we could trace place re-making processes as they unfolded and observe how changes in employees' sense of workplace over time related to changes in formal organizational structure.

Selecting two case organizations allowed us to simultaneously compare and limit variations of internal and external context (Eisenhardt 1989). The organizations are international corporations with subsidiaries in multiple countries. Organization 1 (Org1) operates in the automotive and organization 2 (Org2) in the machinery industry. Both organizations rely on a single organization-wide information and communication technology. These technologies are commonly used, commercially available AICTs that offer various features for synchronous and asynchronous communication, data sharing, and scheduling. However, the two organizations differed in the speed and scope of their transition to hybrid work.

Org1 had initiated plans to establish hybrid work before the first COVID-19 lockdown, introducing a comprehensive AICT in 2018 as part of a "Digital Workplace" project and piloting hybrid work for selected teams in 2019. When the first COVID-19 lockdown forced a shift to fully remote work, corporate leaders welcomed the

accelerated digitalization and flexibilization it brought (expert interview 1). Org2, by contrast, defines itself as a "traditional company" emphasizing face-to-face contact. They introduced a comprehensive AICT only shortly before the first lockdown, and prior to the pandemic permitted home working only in exceptional individual cases. When the first lockdown was lifted, organizational leaders demanded that employees return to the office as quickly as possible. It was only over the following months, amid two additional lockdowns, that Org2 introduced a formal hybrid work policy capping remote work at two days per week (expert interview 2). This difference in policy scope and timing makes the two organizations a theoretically relevant contrasting pair.

3.2 Study informants

In both organizations, we interviewed white-collar employees from Austrian subsidiaries, who performed hybrid work and regularly interacted with AICTs as part of their daily work. Informants were selected with a sampling plan representing a heterogeneous group of individuals varying in job types, leadership responsibilities, and company tenure, who are likely to differ in their hybrid work experience (Schreier 2010).

Our sample includes employees from the following fields of work: Human Resource Management (n = 7), Information Technology (n = 5), Marketing or Product Management (n = 7), Finance (n = 3), and Administration or Customer Service (n = 4). Nine of the 26 informants had leadership responsibilities (35%), and six of the informants were "new employees" (23%) with a company tenure of less than 1.5 years at the time of the first interviews. The two experts were HR managers who oversaw changes to work practices and policies and maintained close contact with both leadership and staff, giving them a vantage point on the structural changes that occurred.

3.3 Data collection

We collected data through three rounds of semi-structured interviews. The first round of employee interviews took place in the fourth quarter of 2020, when most informants were working from home due to COVID-19 restrictions. The second round of interviews took place in the fourth quarter of 2021, when most employees had partly returned to the office, resulting in a hybrid work environment. Three informants had left the organizations by then. We still included insights from the first round of their interviews in our data analysis. The third round consisted of two expert interviews conducted in the first quarter of 2023.

To establish a clear understanding of the organizational context and prevailing formal structure, we opened the first round of employee interviews by asking informants about their individual position (including tasks and role expectations) as well as team membership, reporting structures, and hierarchical relationships. Drawing on place theory, we then asked informants about their experiences of working in physical (office and home) and virtual (AICT-powered) spaces, covering AICT use, work practices, data storage, communication, collaboration, and team interaction across

both spatial contexts. Given the processual character of place-making, in both interview rounds we asked participants how their experiences and place-making activities had evolved between the pre-COVID period and each round of inquiry and which changes (including changes related to formal organizational structure, such as shifts in team membership or reporting lines) had emerged. We phrased all questions open-ended to give informants conversational freedom and to allow unanticipated themes to surface.

The expert interviews contained three main parts: First, we discussed the timeline of events to ensure the accuracy of dates inferred from earlier interviews, and we collected information on relevant developments since the second round of interviews. Second, we asked experts to elaborate on the formal structural changes that had emerged as a theme in the employee interviews, specifically, changes in the grouping of HR positions [1] and reporting relationships as well as related developments in other functions. Third, we presented themes that had emerged from our analysis to assess the experts' opinions and to ask them for relevant additional information. This step functioned as a member check.

3.4 Data analysis

For data analysis, we followed the principles of thematic analysis as defined by Braun and Clarke (2006). Consistent with our structurationist view of organizational reality and with our conceptualization of place as emerging through the interplay between material conditions, organizational practices, and socially constructed meanings, our analysis adopts a contextualist epistemological position. Contextualism occupies a position between realist and constructionist approaches to thematic analysis (Braun and Clarke 2006). It acknowledges that individuals construct meanings from their experiences while these meanings are simultaneously shaped by the material, social, and organizational contexts in which they are embedded. Accordingly, we treat participants' accounts neither as transparent representations of an objective organizational reality nor as purely discursive constructions. Rather, they provide situated accounts of how organizational members experience and make sense of material spaces and formal organizational arrangements, and how these meanings are produced and reproduced through their activities.

Thematic analysis starts with familiarizing with the data. We first deductively defined four coding categories drawing on place theory and Mintzberg's (1979, 1980) structural framework: (1) *Context and structures before hybrid work* (organization environment, team, work task, physical workspace, and AICT), (2) *place-making in the virtual space* (including all features of the AICT, which constitute its materiality (Faraj and Azad 2021): calls, group calls/meetings, chat, e-mail, and others), (3) c*hanges related to communication and collaboration* (drawing on Cresswell 2014; Greer and Payne 2014), and (4) *changing context and structure* (change of formal structure, team, work task, physical space, organization environment, and AICT; see Appendix, Table 1 for coding schema and Tables 2 and 3 for sample quotes).

[1] Please note that the HR experts were part of the central corporate team before the structural change. Thus, they were not the employees directly impacted by the change in grouping.

We coded the whole dataset to ensure completeness, then inductively derived additional sub-categories from the data, capturing themes not anticipated by the theoretical framework (e.g., technical difficulties or AICT-related skills and knowledge). Once the coding was complete, we identified broader themes within our dataset (Braun and Clarke 2006). For this, we considered manifest (i.e., what people explicitly said) as well as latent themes (i.e., underlying topics and ideas; Vaismoradi et al. 2013). Here, we focused our analytical attention on themes that added explanatory value (Braun and Clarke 2006), that is, themes that helped explain *how* and *why* place re-making gave rise to structural changes.

For our analysis, we operationalized changes as developments observable over interview rounds. We identified three types of change: emerging themes (i.e., themes that were prevalent in the second, but not the first round of interviews, indicating new developments), changing themes (i.e., themes present in both rounds of interviews but changed in content or significance, indicating ongoing transformation), and change statements (i.e., explicit statements by interviewees stating that something had changed; Hermanowicz 2013). This allowed us to distinguish between changes that emerged rapidly following the transition to hybrid work and those that developed more gradually, and to compare the pace and nature of change across the two organizations (see Appendix, Table 4 for a comparison of codes between interview rounds and organizations). To present pivotal moments and trace key developments sequentially across the observation period, we additionally employed a visual mapping strategy in the form of a flowchart (see Fig. 2 and Appendix, Table 5 for a detailed timeline; Belizón and Kieran 2022), which allowed us to represent the temporal ordering of place re-making activities and structural changes across both organizations and to facilitate cross-case comparison.

4 Findings

In this paper, we ask *how and through which mechanisms,* the introduction of hybrid work affects formal organizational structure. Figure 1 depicts these mechanisms and orients the presentation that follows, while Fig. 2 contextualizes our findings by setting out the timeline of events in both organizations. In the first Sect. (4.1), we

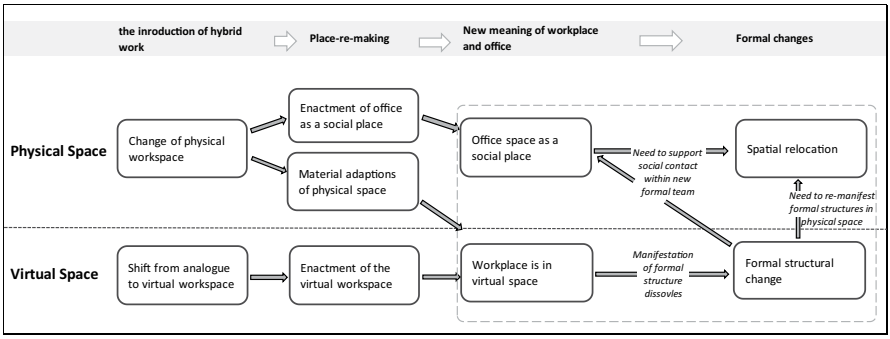


Fig. 1 Place re-making and formal structural change following the introduction of hybrid work

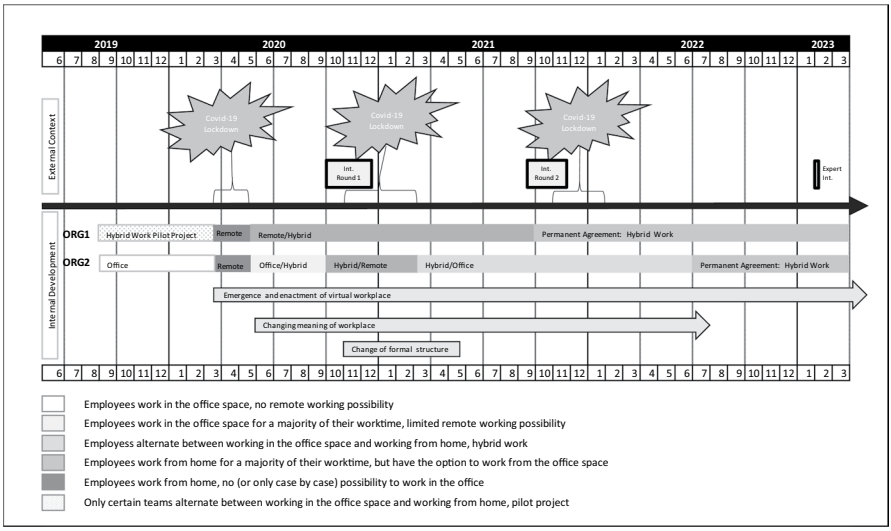


Fig. 2 Timeline of important developments

explain how the *introduction of hybrid work* led to a change of physical work locations as well as a shift from analog to virtual workspaces. We then explain how this triggered *place re-making* in the virtual (i.e., enactment of the virtual workspace) and physical space (i.e., material adaptations), which led to a *new meaning of the workplace* as being virtual (see also Fig. 3). In the next Sect. (4.2), we describe the *formal structural change* that followed (see also Fig. 4). Here, we elaborate on how the newly emerged virtual workplace loosened the spatial manifestation that the existing formal structure rested on and how this made established arrangements open to revision. Finally (4.3), we show how place re-making in the physical space, which had initially supported the virtual workplace, gave the *office new meaning as a place* of social connectedness (see also Fig. 5) and thereby made the spatial relocation of the newly constituted formal teams meaningful.

4.1 Establishment of virtual workplace

At the start of our observation period, the office space held an unambiguous meaning as "the workplace" in both organizations. As shown in Fig. 2, the first COVID-19 lockdown in 2020 triggered the rapid introduction of remote work, initiating a process of place re-making. Employees in both organizations reported challenges associated with the abrupt transition, including technical difficulties, inadequate equipment, and reluctance to discuss sensitive matters through digital channels. These challenges were more pronounced in Org2, which had no prior remote work experience and had only recently introduced a comprehensive AICT.

During these early stages, place-making activities in both organizations were oriented toward temporary solutions rather than a lasting transformation, as organizational members anticipated a swift return to the physical office. When the first lockdown was lifted, however, the two organizations diverged. Org1 maintained

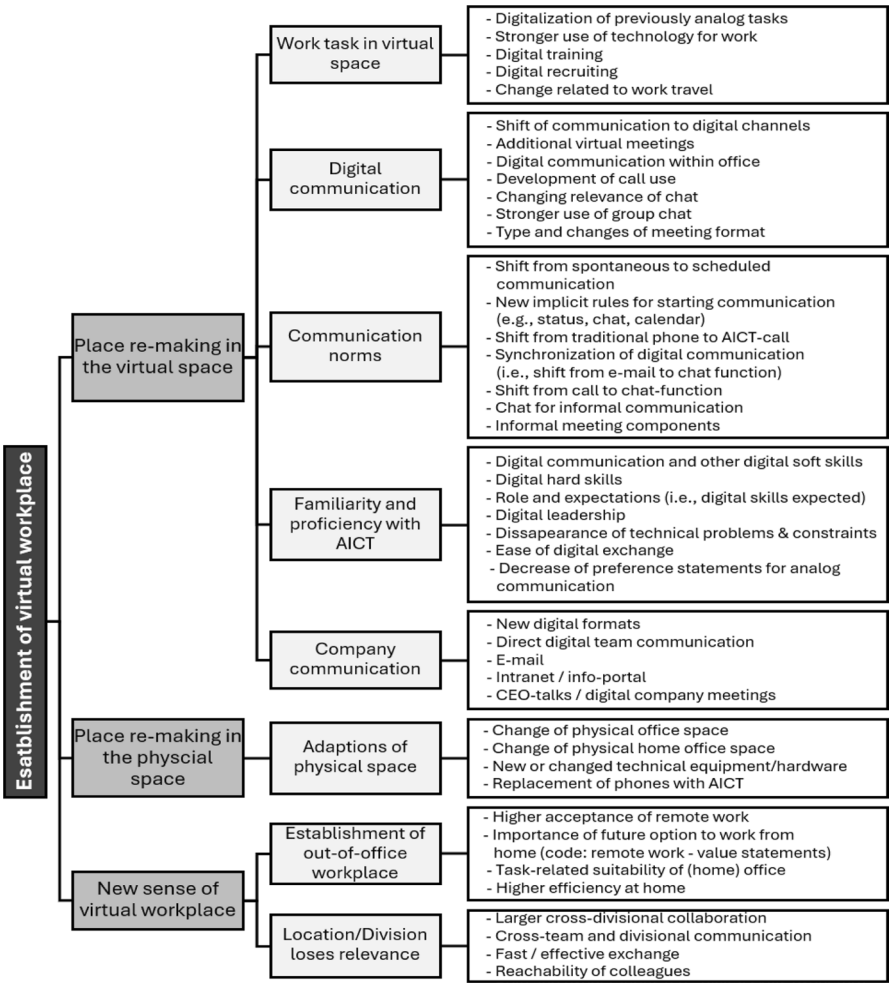


Fig. 3 Thematic data structure of place re-making and changed sense of workplace

a permissive remote work policy and most white-collar employees transitioned to hybrid work on an ongoing basis, while Org2's employees largely returned to the office. Org2 introduced a formal hybrid work policy only after two subsequent lockdowns. As hybrid work became established, employees in both organizations reported fewer difficulties and higher familiarity with virtual work, progressively enacting the virtual space as a place in its own right, a development that occurred earlier and more rapidly in Org1.

The ongoing enactment of this virtual workplace constitutes place re-making, encompassing several recurring themes, shown in Fig. 3. These themes describe newly established practices and norms, as well as changes observed between the two interview rounds, and they include the digitalization of previously analog tasks (*work task in virtual space*), an increase in *digital communication* even when working in the office space, and the emergence of new digital *communication norms*, including new

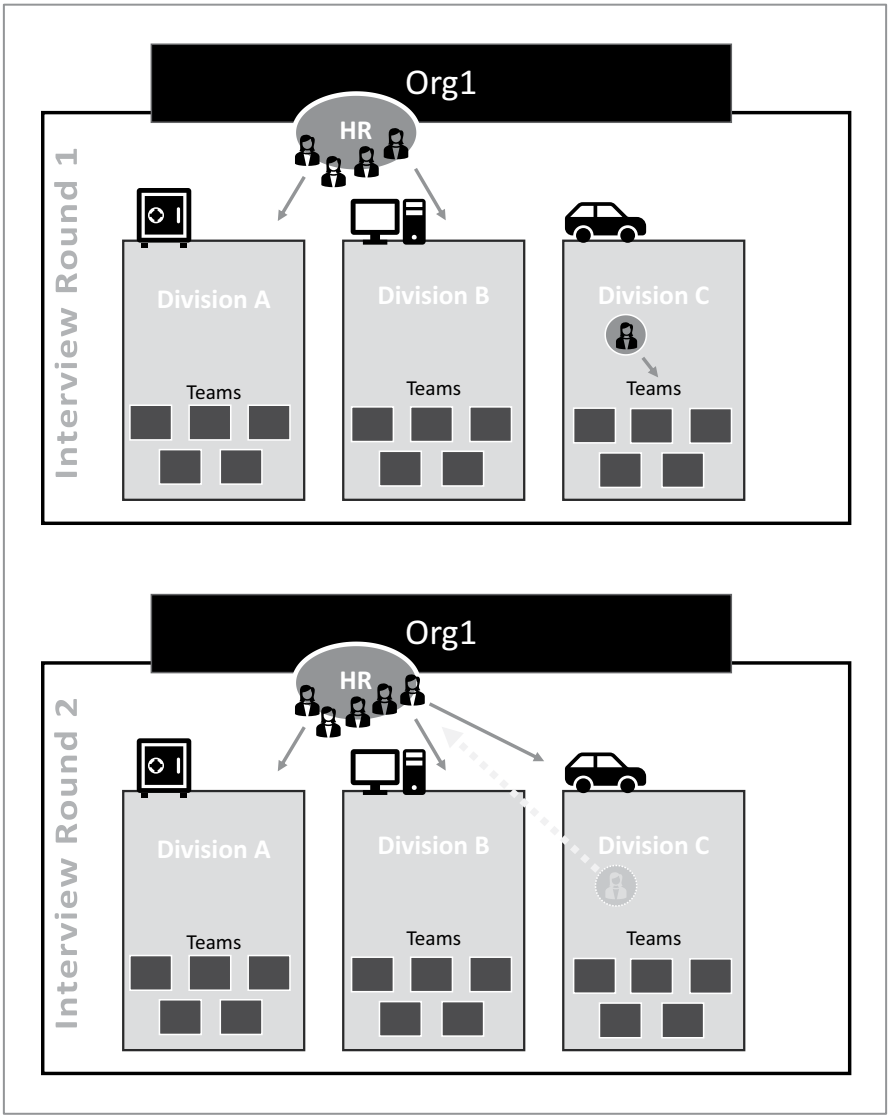


Fig. 4 Functional centralization of HR—example

implicit rules for starting communication and the incorporation of informal communication into previously formal channels. Employees also report *higher familiarity with AICTs* and the introduction of new virtualized forms of *company communication*. We also identified *material adaptations of the physical space*, including the office and "home office", which strengthen the establishment of the virtual workplace. Examples of these adaptations include setting up dedicated work rooms at home, equipping meeting rooms in the office space for virtual group calls, or providing new hardware, all with the purpose of facilitating the enactment of the virtual workplace.

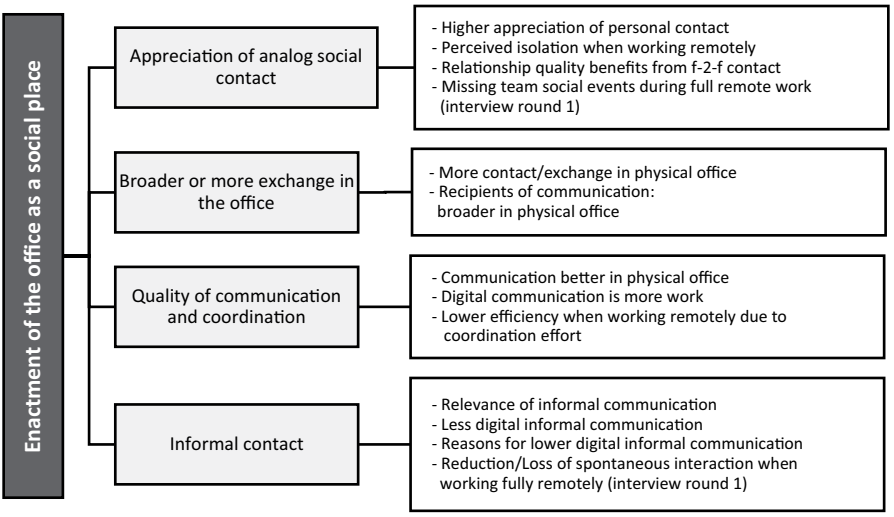


Fig. 5 Thematic data structure of enactment of the office as a social place

Taken together, these place re-making activities led to the emergence of a virtual workplace. Two themes in the second round of interviews speak directly to this: the first is the *establishment of an out-of-office workplace*. Members of both organizations describe more openness to working outside the physical office space. Employees verbally express the desire or expectation to continue working (part-) remotely in the future, and they plan and schedule their work location based on the task at hand. The second, which was more pronounced in Org1, is that the *location and division lose relevance*. As work is conducted in the virtual workplace, distance matters less and collaboration with colleagues from other locations (whether that is a different office or a different subsidiary altogether) becomes easier.

The emergence and continued enactment of the virtual workplace has fundamentally altered employees ' sense of workplace. Where the concept of "workplace" was previously inextricably tied to the physical office, its sustained virtual enactment has decoupled it from any fixed physical location, and employees now experience their workplace as inherently virtual rather than spatially anchored. As we will elaborate in the next section, this shift is structurally consequential as the office had given the formal structure a spatial manifestation. The newly established virtual workplace no longer performs this function.

4.2 Functional centralization

Alongside the establishment of a virtual workplace and the declining significance of the physical office as a primary work location, our second round of interviews revealed a change in formal organizational structure in both organizations. Specifically, we observe a shift in two parameters of organizational structure: configuration and centralization. Configuration specifies the general principles for dividing the work, breaking it into tasks and forming positions and units (Burton and Obel 2004).

Well-known structural configurations are functional and divisional. We find that HR work is reconfigured from part-divisional grouping, in which some HR practitioners were embedded within the operational divisions they served, toward purely functional grouping, in which all HR practitioners are consolidated within a centralized HR unit. This shift is accompanied by a change in reporting relationships. HR practitioners now report to the central HR manager rather than to their respective divisional heads, representing an increase in vertical centralization of the HR function. We refer to this change as *functional organization and centralization*.

This change occurred in the HR function of both organizations. Our expert informant from Org1 reported that a similar change happened in the Finance function of their organization. However, due to a lack of detailed information and for clarity of presentation, we describe the development using the case of HR. Prior to the introduction of hybrid work, both organizations maintained a central HR team at the corporate level. However, HR practitioners performing the same tasks for specific divisions were formally embedded within those divisions. This form of part-divisional grouping had evolved organically over time. For instance, an HR practitioner overseeing administrative tasks (e.g., timekeeping) for the warehouse department in Org2 was formally a member of the warehouse department, held a designated workstation within the warehouse, and reported to the warehouse manager despite having no functional overlap with other warehouse employees. We refer to this as a decentralized, divisionally grouped structure. As explained in the expert interviews, this arrangement had become so institutionalized and taken for granted that it went unquestioned even though consolidating HR functions into a central functional unit might have yielded coordination efficiencies well before the shift to hybrid work.

By the time of the second interview round, this decentralized structure had been formally reorganized (see Fig. 4). Previously divisionally assigned HR practitioners were now members of the central HR team, subject to unified functional supervision and reporting to the central HR manager, while continuing to carry out the same tasks and support the same employees, teams, and divisions as before.

This structural change is closely connected to the emergence of a virtual workplace. Place theory helps to explain the underlying mechanisms as a physical workspace gives spatial manifestation to formal structures. Dedicated office units and workstations make the division of labor, reporting relationships, and team membership materially visible, with employees working in physical proximity to their formal superiors and team members (Taylor and Spicer 2007). This was the case in Org1 and Org2, where the physical materialization (e.g., HR practitioners sitting with the teams they provided services for) reinforced the decentralized, divisionally grouped structure and contributed to its taken-for-grantedness.

As the virtual workplace took hold, this spatial manifestation of formal structure was disrupted. A virtual workplace does not anchor formal structures in the same way as the office space. Although organizational members attempted to replicate formal structural arrangements digitally (e.g., through AICT team channels), the spatial mapping of reporting relationships and team membership was absent, which is prevalent in codes about location losing relevance. For example, one interviewee explained:

> *"[…] there are colleagues in the department who sit in [office location A], who sit in [office location B], in [office location C], in [office location D], and at three locations in [different state]. The exchange between us in the decentralized team is exactly the same as between the people who sit for example only in [office location A]. […] this influence of distances does not exist at all with us." (Interview 1).*

The absence of formal structure's spatial manifestation weakened the taken-for-grantedness of the previously established part-divisional configuration and gave organizational decision makers the opportunity to question or even change existing formal structures. In both organizations, senior decision makers (i.e., HR managers) seized this opportunity to integrate previously decentralized HR practitioners into the central HR unit, thereby increasing the vertical centralization of the function and consolidating their own span of authority.

It is worth mentioning again that the formal structural change was confined to specific functions (HR in both organizations, Finance in Org1), even though we found the place re-making activities and the emergence of a virtual workplace across all teams. Informants in other fields of work reported unchanged positions and reporting relationships. What is specific about HRM in both cases is its organization prior to the introduction of hybrid work. Our findings therefore suggest that the observed functional organization and centralization is tied to a specific structural constellation, namely part-divisional grouping, which we observed in support functions that provide services across divisions. However, our data do not allow us to rule out comparable developments for other functions.

4.3 Spatial relocation of HR: a paradox?

While place re-making in the physical space had so far supported the enactment of a virtual workplace, it now takes on a second role. In Org1, spatial relocation was used to consolidate the restructuring process and give material expression to the newly centralized formal structure. This means that following the functional organization and centralization, HR practitioners physically relocated their workstations within the office to sit alongside their new team members. In Org2, there was no spatial relocation following the functional shift. However, during the expert interview, we learned that this was due to spatial restrictions. Discussions regarding potential location-changes for the entire HR department to unify the team spatially were ongoing at the time of the expert interview.

This raises an apparent paradox. At the point of relocation, employees no longer experienced the office as their primary workplace and they reported a decreased relevance of the location of workstations or colleagues. HR practitioners worked predominantly from home, enacting their workplace virtually and rendering the location of their office workstation seemingly inconsequential in terms of day-to-day work. Why, then, did the spatial manifestation of the new structure matter? Place theory provides an explanation.

Our data indicate that while the virtual space had been successfully enacted as a workplace, it did not fully satisfy employees' need for social contact. This was

consistent across both interview rounds and both organizations, irrespective of differences in AICT familiarity or pace of adaptation to remote work. Some employees perceive(d) isolation while working remotely. They missed social events and explained that the relationship quality within the team suffered from the lack of face-to-face contact.

> *"What I missed the most in the home office, […] these two minutes to be allowed to 'throw up' [= rant], with the colleague about something. That's just missing when you jump from [virtual] appointment to appointment. You always have to remain friendly, always professional and, when I have my colleague here, and we sit next to each other for eight hours a day, he knows me exactly and I know that I can also vent my frustration with him for a minute." (Interview 26)*

Therefore, employees enact the physical office space as a *place for social connectedness*, a distinct and newly constituted meaning of the office, which partially replaced its prior meaning as the primary site of work. In our data, we found four themes that characterize the enactment of the office space as a social space (see Fig. 5).

There is higher *appreciation and active seeking of analog social contact* within the office space, and employees return to the office to engage in face-to-face meetings and satisfy their need for social contact. In addition, employees report having *more and broader exchanges* (i.e., with more colleagues) in the physical office space compared to the virtual workplace, and that the *quality of communication and coordination* is better in the office. There is also more *informal contact* in the physical space compared to the virtual space, and employees actively seek spontaneous and informal encounters in the office.

Employees thus develop a new sense of the office as a place of social connection and informal organizational life:

> *"The reason I go to the office has perhaps changed a bit. […] We have now introduced solutions with our Digital Workplace. […] today, for once, I'm sitting in the office again […] because today the colleagues have ordered burgers, yes. And that is (laughs), such a small tradition, Wednesday there is always a snack with the team leaders, yes. That's also such a social aspect." (Interview 5)*

Given the office's reconstituted sense of place as a site of social connectedness, spatial relocation serves as a meaningful way to consolidate the newly formed formal structure, operating on two levels simultaneously. At the *individual level*, it facilitates social interaction among members of newly constituted formal teams, allowing new team membership to be experienced and enacted in the physical space. At the *managerial level*, it re-manifests the changed reporting relationships and functional grouping in the physical space, giving the new formal structure material and symbolic durability, a function that, as shown by our findings, the virtual workplace alone cannot fulfill. The physical space thus contributed to the structural development in two ways: first, by enabling the enactment of the virtual workplace, and later, by giving the new formal structure material expression.

5 Discussion

With the continued diffusion of hybrid work, scholars have called for a deeper understanding of how spatially flexible work arrangements affect organizations – now and in the near future (Leone 2023). This paper responds to this call by showing that place re-making in both the virtual and physical space not only transforms employees' sense of their workplace and the office, but also challenges and reshapes established formal organizational structures. In both observed organizations, a shift to hybrid work was followed by a tendency toward functional organization and centralization of previously decentralized HR positions, accompanied by spatial relocation. Both organizations introduced hybrid work partly as a forced consequence of the COVID-19 pandemic, and partly as a means to benefit from typical promises of remote work such as higher flexibility, performance, and job satisfaction (Gajendran and Harrison 2007; Martin and MacDonnell 2012). The observed functional centralization of HR was thus a consequence of place re-making rather than a deliberate outcome of either organization's hybrid work policy.

Discussions of organizational forms within the FoW debate prominently feature arrangements that loosen organizational boundaries, such as gig work (e.g., Dries et al. 2025; Barley et al. 2017) and a stronger reliance on freelancing, with governance shifting away from traditional hierarchical mechanisms (Malhotra 2021). What happens to formal structures within the organization has received comparatively little attention in the FoWliterature, and when it is discussed, higher spatial flexibility is often associated with organizational models such as holacracy, which accentuate decentralization and flexible roles (Schmitz 2018). In this study hybrid work facilitated the opposite, namely functional organization and centralization. This is consistent with a broader pattern in the NWW literature, a related field concerned with the organizational design of flexible work. Here, empirical studies repeatedly find that spatially flexible arrangements produce outcomes that diverge from organizational intentions (Renard et al. 2021). For example, van Steenbergen et al. (2018) found that NWW may lead to reduced autonomy despite higher flexibility. Our study extends this pattern to the domain of formal organizational structure, showing that unanticipated consequences of spatial flexibilization go beyond employee-level outcomes.

Looking closer at the structural change, it becomes clear that the formal restructuring unfolded at different speeds in the two organizations.Org1, with its prior AICT familiarity and more permissive remote work policy, underwent virtual place-making more rapidly than Org2. In addition, in both organizations it was HR managers who identified and acted upon the window of opportunity (drawing on Barley 1986; Tyre and Orlikowski 1994) created by the introduction of hybrid work. Thus, our findings draw attention to the important role of contextual factors, such as managerial agency or organizational culture in determining the pace and nature of changes following hybrid work. This aligns with Joyce et al.'s (2023) call to move beyond technological determinism and instead investigate the role of social and institutional agency when studying the implementation of new technologies.

Finally, our findings regarding the changed meaning of the office as a place for social connectedness are worth mentioning. A prominent question related to the future of work is how to avoid professional isolation (Cooper and Kurland 2002; Golden et

al. 2008), and how to facilitate communication and collaboration (Fuchs and Reichel 2023; Greer & Payne 2014) when employees work spatially dispersed from one another. Existing research shows that the targeted appropriation of AICTs can enable virtual communication (Malhotra and Majchrzak 2014). Hu et al. (2022), however, offer a more nuanced view on AICT-enabled virtual collaboration, showing that the conditions for successful collaboration differ within and between organizational units, and that arrangements serving one level may constrain the other. Specialized technologies serve individual teams but may hamper collaboration between teams, while centralized technologies facilitate inter-team collaboration but may not serve individual teams successfully. Consistent with Hu et al. (2022), employees in both organizations, which had introduced organization-wide AICT platforms, reported that collaboration across location and divisional boundaries had become easier. Nevertheless, the question remains whether online interactions can fully substitute face-to-face contact or whether the two are better described as complementary (Vartiainen and Vanharanta 2024). Our findings show that the virtual workplace, despite its ability to foster successful collaboration, does not suffice in meeting employees' need for social contact. The office maintains an important role as a place for social connectedness. Therefore, the present paper raises caution when it comes to fully substituting the physical office as a place of work with a virtual one.

6 Theoretical & practical implications

This study makes two main theoretical contributions. First, it links research on the future of work with a place perspective, an approach that has been well established in geography and urban studies (e.g., Friedmann 2010; Pierce et al. 2011), but less so in managerial research (Cartel et al. 2022). The concept of space is already anchored in research on hybrid work. For example, Lauring and Jonasson (2025) consider location (i.e., the physical space) and modality (i.e., analog vs. virtual work) as two main dimensions of hybrid work. They propose capturing the extent of alternations within these dimensions to measure hybridity and they call for research into how employees' perception of hybrid work changes over time. A place lens makes it possible to investigate individuals' shifting perception or, in the terms of place theory, *sense* of place by showing how they experience and enact it in everyday work (Cartel et al. 2022). In doing so, it extends the notion of space and place within the FoW debate from an analytical dimension to a processual one, whose evolution itself can be studied.

Place theory postulates that individuals not only experience places but also enact and give material form to them (i.e., place-making; Cilliers and Timmermans 2014). This allows researchers to connect spatial changes to organizational transformations by shedding light on the place re-making activities and the shifting meaning of places (Svobodova et al. 2023; Taylor and Spicer 2007). Through a place lens we view the introduction of hybrid work as a spatial transformation that alters the places through which organizational members experience work, hierarchy, team membership, and coordination. It is therefore particularly useful for explaining why hybrid work may produce broader organizational consequences beyond individual-level outcomes.

Second, our findings extend organizational research by demonstrating the mechanisms through which hybrid work can trigger *formal* structural change. While place theory has illuminated how spatial meaning shapes behavioral norms and organizational identities (Harrison and Dourish 1996; Gieryn 2000) and gives spatial manifestation to both formal and informal structures (Taylor and Spicer 2007), it has not been systematically connected to *formal structural change*. Our findings suggest that this connection is not only possible but theoretically productive. Place theory's concept of spatial manifestation helps explain why formally prescribed structures persist even when their functional rationale is unclear, and what conditions render them vulnerable to change. This paper specifically demonstrates how ongoing place-making activities lead to the emergence of a virtual workplace whose materiality plays an important role in explaining formal organizational change.

For practitioners, the notion of a new meaning of the office as a place for social connectedness carries significant implications. A key question concerning the future of work is what role physical settings (e.g., offices, headquarters) will play for collaborative work in partly or mostly virtual organizations (Malhotra 2021). When large numbers of employees work independently of the office, companies tend to reduce office space, treating it primarily as a cost-optimization opportunity (Naor et al. 2022). Our findings counsel against this. Even when employees primarily work from home, the office retains an irreplaceable function as a place for social contact, informal exchange, and face-to-face collaboration. As the office no longer serves as the main workplace for hybrid employees, but rather as a place to seek social contact, requirements for the office layout may change. Rather than minimizing office space, the notion of the *social office* points toward a different design logic: configuring the office in ways that actively foster collaboration and social exchange, for example by choosing a more open office layout, by providing enough meeting rooms, or by purposefully designing collaborative spaces. Empirical evidence supports this design logic by showing that freely accessible open workspaces foster social interactions, which in turn positively impact work engagement (Gerards et al. 2018a, b). They also increase the frequency of feedback employees receive, with positive downstream effects on informal learning (Gerards et al. 2018a, b). Furthermore, research on activity-based office environments suggests that realizing these benefits depends as much on the implementation process as on the physical design of the office itself, with a spatial layout that balances communication and concentration identified as a critical success factor (Brunia et al. 2016).

7 Limitations and future research

Limiting our research to two case organizations may restrict the generalizability of our findings. It remains open to question whether our findings can be transferred to smaller or mid-sized organizations, more locally operating companies, or firms in other industry sectors. Larger-scale studies would therefore be valuable for testing whether the functional organization and centralization of HR positions we observed represents a broader phenomenon.

A further limitation concerns our access within the organizations. We did not have the opportunity to interview organizational decision makers, i.e., the HR managers at corporate level, who proposed and facilitated the structural change. As a result, we had to infer HR managers' motivations for the functional organization and centralization from the expert interviews. The addition of corporate-level interviews would have strengthened the analysis but was not possible for this project.

Our observation period represents a third limitation. We collected data during the COVID-19 pandemic, a period of rapid and largely externally imposed spatial disruption. This raises the question of whether similar place re-making dynamics and structural consequences would emerge under more gradual or voluntary transitions to hybrid work. Longitudinal research spanning a longer post-pandemic timeframe would also allow scholars to examine whether the reconstitution of the office as a place of social connectedness is sustained as office attendance increases, or whether a new sense of place gradually re-emerges as the office regains its role as a primary work site.

Another avenue of future research is the investigation of consequences. Our findings document the structural change and the mechanism through which it occurred, but they do not extend to its consequences. Future studies could examine how this type of emergent, place-driven structural reorganization affects leadership styles and practices, or organizational climate. Studies could also look into employees' individual experiences. For example, how is this change experienced by those who initiate it and by those directly affected by it, and are there differences? Research into team dynamics and HR practices within the newly constituted centralized HR teams and into the relationships between these teams and the divisions they continue to serve, would also yield valuable insights.

A related question concerns the scope of our findings with respect to functional boundaries. Our study identified centralization in the HR function (and Finance, in Org1), but did not observe equivalent changes in other departments during the observation period. Whether the dynamics we describe are specific to support functions characterized by cross-divisional service provision, or whether they extend to operational, strategic, and line functions (Lunenburg 2012) where a comparable misalignment between formal grouping and spatial manifestation exists, remains to be investigated.

A final promising avenue for future research concerns the role of AICT materiality in shaping virtual place-making activities. Sociomaterial theory (Leonardi 2013), affordance theory (Volkoff and Strong 2017), or structuration theories (DeSanctis and Poole 1994) could provide valuable tools for analyzing how specific technological features or norms inscribed into the virtual workplace relate to organizational outcomes.

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Data availability The data collected and analyzed in this study are available on request from the corresponding author. The data are not publicly available because they include information about specific

organizations and statements that could compromise the privacy of research participants/employees of these organizations.

Declarations

Conflict of interest The authors report no conflict of interest for this paper.

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